

Taylor the Turtle: My Body Belongs To Me!!

Grant Recognition

What we want to say for the grant recognition:

Funded by the Ministry of Children and Community and Social Services, Ontario's Action Plan to End Gender-Based Violence.

This project is designed to expand and deliver child sexual abuse prevention programming to families, agencies, and sectors that interact with children. These groups will have the opportunity to participate in Taylor the Turtle, a now 16-year collaboration developed by eight community partners in the Brantford/Brant County and Six Nations communities under the leadership of the Sexual Assault Centre of Brant (SAC Brant) and Ganohkwasra Family Assault Support Services (Ganohkwasra).

Taylor the Turtle trains Caring Adults to provide developmentally appropriate information and promote emotional literacy for young ones aged 18 months to six years and beyond. This dynamic program is built on Indigenous knowledge and the expertise developed over decades of sexual abuse prevention work and collective efforts to create a disclosure safe community.

Content for the History page

Early Development

Taylor the Turtle was created in 2010 in response to concerns about traditional child sexual abuse prevention programs that relied heavily on fear-based messaging and abstract "stranger danger" scenarios. While facilitating prevention sessions in an elementary school classroom, Program Founder Carrie Sinkoski observed that children struggled to understand scenario-based lessons and often became confused, distressed, or overly focused on literal details rather than safety concepts.

Many commonly used "good touch/bad touch" programs were also found to be triggering for survivors, developmentally inappropriate for young children, and ineffective in reflecting how abuse most often occurs, typically within trusted relationships rather than through strangers.

Taylor the Turtle was developed as a community-informed alternative grounded in children's rights, body awareness, emotional literacy, and safety planning. Drawing on research, frontline experience with survivors, and feedback from educators, the program focuses on strengthening protective factors such as self-esteem, strong adult connections, and the ability to recognize and express feelings.

Since its creation, Taylor the Turtle has been shaped through ongoing community input and has been delivered across schools and community settings. It was later recognized by the province as a best practice prevention initiative.

Creators

Carrie Sinkowski

Program Founder aka Taylor's Mom

A long-time community developer, Carrie's passion for community started early: growing up in her grandfather's store and surrounded by care and connection. That same spirit helped bring Taylor the Turtle to life.

Tales with Taylor: Carrie has so many favourite times with Taylor! Creating the program with her family and community colleagues would be the top highlight. There are so many stories from when Taylor was out and about in classrooms, summer camps, and community events that make her smile.

Katie Sinkowski

Graphic Designer

Katie Sinkowski is a Registered Graphic Designer with over two decades of experience bringing creative ideas to life!

Tales with Taylor: Katie's favourite memory of Taylor was when we created the Taylor stuffies. Watching her kids play with their own mini-Taylors made it especially meaningful. She says, "It was a pretty memorable moment to watch my design come to life like that!"

John Sinkowski

Artist and Co-Creator

John Sinkowski has recently retired after working for over 50 years at Stoney's Home Hardware in Port Dover!

He received the industry's "Golden Hammer" to recognize his contribution to the hardware industry. During his time at Stoney's he volunteered with the Port Dover Fire Department working in both fire suppression and fire safety education. John was a member of a provincial committee that worked together to bring "Risk Watch", a children's safety program, to Canada.

Tales with Taylor: A love and passion for art and drawing, combined with his experiences in community work, lead to his participation in creating the Taylor the Turtle program with his two daughters. He describes Taylor as being an exciting part of his life. Two of his favourite memories of working with Taylor include the launch party at Woodland Cultural Centre, and the creation of the storybook, "The Riverbank Project". Though perhaps his favourite memory was seeing Taylor brought to life in stuffy form, and witnessing the smiles those turtles bring for little ones.

Jean Sinkowski

Curriculum Consultant aka Taylor's Nan

Jean Sinkowski is a retired primary teacher and has been a caring consultant for the Taylor the Turtle program, helping ensure the curriculum remains developmentally appropriate and engaging for children of all ages.

Tales with Taylor: Jean's favourite memory is remembering the excitement of Taylor's launch in 2010 and watching the program continue to grow and expand throughout the years. Her care, knowledge, and dedication have helped families and communities know today.

Early Adoption

Advisory Committee:

- SAC Brant
- Ganohkwasra Family Assault Support Services
- Grand Erie District School Board
- Victim Services of Brant
- Woodview Children's Services and
- St. Leonard's (SOAR) Community Services
- Nova Vita Domestic Violence Prevention Services
- Brantford Police Services

Staff Information

SAC Brant

Jezeth Esmas

Community Development Coordinator

Jezeth Esmas connects community members with tools and support to help children (and adults!) learn about their body rights, how to express their feelings, and feel safe. She's passionate about building strong, caring networks where everyone can grow and thrive.

Her work blends digital innovation, community engagement, and consent education to help children, youth, and families build confidence, safety awareness, and self-expression.

Jezeth's daily reminder is: I am becoming the kind of person who I would love to meet.

Alex Klapwyk

Placement Student, Child and Youth Worker

Alex Klapwyk first joined SAC Brant as a placement student through Laurier and returned to us through Canada Summer Jobs. She's been a great addition to the Taylor the Turtle team, bringing optimism and all the fun while diving headfirst into the community to spread awareness about Taylor's Rights. We like to say she's even developed a bit of an alter ego!

Alex is currently studying for her Bachelor's in Social Work, and loves reading and spending time outdoors.

Alex's daily reminder is: Wake up every morning with the thought that something wonderful is about to happen.

Ganohkwasra Family Assault Support Services

Misty Greene

Child and Youth Councillor

Misty Greene is a proud community member of Six Nations. She loves working with the children at her organization and is looking forward to the upcoming year as a representative for Taylor the Turtle at Ganohkwasra.

As part of the Taylor the Turtle team, Misty brings care, cultural connection, and a deep love for working with children, supporting them every step of the way.

Misty's daily reminder is: Every day is a brand-new day for us to begin a new journey.

Ashley Maracle-Hill

Bio to come soon.

Research Team

Dr. Marcia Oliver

Associate Professor, Law & Society, Wilfrid Laurier University

As a researcher, Marcia Oliver strives for ethical, community-engaged, social justice-oriented research. She's worked on a range of projects, including other collaborations with SAC Brant and a recent study on the impacts of trafficking laws on shaping sex workers' lives and working conditions. Marcia is also part of the co-director team leading the Walls to Bridges program in support of transformative prison education. She's not a fan of symmetry, but is quite fond of people with sass, and she's so grateful for the communities in her life that bring her hope and joy in the world.

Wonu Oluwo

Research and Placement Student, Event Planner

Bio to come soon.

Kasey Politano

Research Assistant, Community Development Coordinator

Kasey Politano holds a Master of Arts in Social Justice and Community Engagement and has spent over ten years working in sexual and gender-based violence across research, shelter, counselling, post-secondary, and community coordination settings. She is committed to survivor-centred, intersectional practice and believes that supporting people who have experienced harm means taking seriously the systems that shape their lives.

Her work focuses on community development, gender equity, and violence prevention through education, research, and advocacy.

Dr. Jennifer Root

Associate Professor & Associate Dean (BSW), Faculty of Social Work, Wilfrid Laurier University

Jenn Root's approach to research and community work is rooted in principles of intersectional feminisms and anti-oppressive practices. Prior to joining Laurier and the Brantford/Brant communities, Jenn worked as a social worker alongside various communities in southwestern Ontario and the Midwest US supporting anti-violence prevention and intervention work, primarily on issues related to women's experiences of intimate partner violence, gender-based violence, and sexual violence. Over the past 10 years, she's been lucky enough to work alongside Joanna Brant (Executive Director) and the amazing folks at SAC Brant, and most recently, supporting all things Taylor the Turtle.

Articles

What we want for the "articles" section:

- Pending, list coming soon.

Taylor the Turtle

Taylor's Teachings

[Include respective photos for each teaching]

1. My body belongs to me!!
2. I have the right to a healthy body!!
3. I have the right to a safe body!!
4. I have the right to a safe school!!
5. I have the right to a safe community!!
6. I have the right to talk to someone when I don't feel safe!!
7. I have the right to be safe online!!
8. I have the right to be myself!!
9. I have the right to be proud of my family!!
10. I have the right to be cared for during emergencies!!

Taylor's Music

[Embed <https://soundcloud.com/taylor-the-turtle>]

Colouring Pages

[Downloadable PDFs of the colouring pages]

Photo Catalogue

[Images from past and recent events]

For Facilitators

[A password-protected page that will contain resources for folks who've received facilitator training for the Taylor the Turtle program]

